many mild cases of Omicron resulted in severe fatigue even after other symptoms receded. "Different people have different severity of Covid-19. What we are seeing is that regardless of severity, some patients are reporting weakness post recovery," says Dr Chandrashekhar T., director, critical care, Fortis Hiranandani Hospital, Mumbai.

CFS, though, is not surprising post-Covid as the body expends significant energy and resources in defending the cells from the viral infection. Doctors say such fatigue is common during the recovery period of many illnesses—malaria, typhoid, dengue and influenza, among others. "The body needs time to recover and in the initial days after symptoms subside, there will be some signs of weakness," says Dr Vivek Nangia, pulmonologist at Max Super Speciality Hospital, Saket, New Delhi.

How long the weakness lasts is subject to how severe a disease the person had. A January 2022 study in Norway looked at 66 Omicron-positive patients and found that, on an average, their fatigue lasted for seven to 14 days from the start of their Covid symptoms.

NUTRITION IS KEY

"How fast patients recover is also dependent on the nutritional intake of the patient during and after the disease," says Dr Chandrashekhar. "Eating a diet rich in minerals and vitamins is, along with adequate rest, essential for the body to recover and heal from any illness," adds Dr Vaishali Verma, nutritionist, Manipal Hospital, Delhi.

A 2021 PubMed study found that certain foods—eggs, seafood, fruits, meat, milk, starchy roots, stimulants, nuts, vegetable oil and vegetables—had a positive impact on Covid recovery. In general, consumption of higher levels of proteins and lipids have been shown to have a positive effect on recovery from the virus. "I ate a lot of pro- and prebiotic foods during my recovery and it helped restore my energy and balance out the impact of the virus on my digestion. Yoghurt, buttermilk, *kaanji* and kombucha were my go-to choices," says Kuldeep Singh, a 39-year-old Omicron survivor from Delhi. As per Delhi-based clinical nutritionist Dr Megha Jaina, a diet rich in fresh fruit and vegetables can help replenish energy levels more effectively than chemical vitamin supplements as the body absorbs nutrients from natural sources much better. "Balance and variety make a post-Covid diet healthy. If there are digestive symptoms, like acidity, bloating or constipation, then consult a nutritionist to restore healthy gut bacteria," she says.

MENTAL WELLBEING

In addition to proper nutrition, it is also important that patients reduce their mental stress. "There is widespread anxiety and panic regarding the virus because of social media," says Dr Chandrashekhar. "Many messages online are true, but many are false and lead to rumour-mongering, which, in turn, increases mental stress in many patients. The best recommendation is to consult a doctor. One's treatment during and after Covid has to be devised keeping in mind the patient's condition and health parameters."

Mumbai-based psychiatrist Dr Kedar Tilwe adds that mental stress can have a debilitating impact on physical energy and hamper the body's natural recovery process from the disease. "Anxiety, poor sleep and stress will add to physical fatigue," he says.

Low energy and weakness can be difficult to handle and understand. Many doctors say that patients feel stressed when they aren't able to resume everyday activities immediately. But, as experts say, rest, nutrition and mental relaxation go hand in hand when coping with this lingering symptom of Covid. ■

WHILE FATIGUE HAS BEEN A COMMON SYMPTOM OF COVID, OMICRON HAS SEEN A RISE IN INSTANCES OF FATIGUE EVEN AMONG MILD CASES

IS THE THIRD WAVE OVER?

After two months, the Omicron wave in India seems to have receded. From an R-value of 4 in the first week of 2022, the highest ever recorded during the pandemic, to the current 1.3, critical parameters are pointing to a reduction in both the number of cases and the pace of spread of infection. In all metros, the R-value, a measure of how many people a single positive patient can infect, was less than 1, including Kolkata, Mumbai, Delhi and Chennai. India reported 83,876 new Covid cases on February 8, while the positivity rate dropped to 7.25 per cent. It is still above the WHO-recommended 5 per cent, but significantly lower than the 16.2 per cent reported in the first week of January 2022. This is also the first time since January 6 that India's daily Covid tally did not go above 100,000. The decline in Covid cases has prompted many states to reopen schools, malls, gyms and offices and increase the permitted size of public gatherings.

A similar trend with Omicron has been reported across the world with the WHO noting that in most countries, the wave, having peaked already, is currently in decline. However, the global health body continues to warn against complacency, so as to not allow more Covid variants to come up. Vaccines in particular are critical to ending the pandemic—the sooner the world is fully vaccinated against the current dominant strains, the lesser the chances of new strains arising. In India, while vaccinations for children under the age of 15 are still on hold as the DCGI awaits more safety data, the country has approved nine vaccines for use and already vaccinated over 70 per cent of the adult population. Experts say this is one of the reasons why the Omicron wave was shorter and the symptoms were significantly less severe than the Delta wave. The the highest single day death in the Omicron wave was 1,733, against 4,300 for Delta. As India continues to open up, vaccinating the entire population remains key to ensure any future fourth wave will end quickly and cause even less damage.